Prime Minister Charan Singh's government then came to power, backed by the Congress, but could last only twenty-three days as Indira Gandhi withdrew her party's support. Parliament was dissolved and mid-term elections to the seventh Lok Sabha were held in January 1980, in which Indira Gandhi and the Congress returned to power. For his loyalty to Sanjay Gandhi, Kamal Nath, originally from Kanpur in Uttar Pradesh, was rewarded with a 'safe' parliamentary seat at Chhindwara in Madhya Pradesh, which he easily won in those elections.

Emboldened by his success in manipulating political developments at the national level, Sanjay Gandhi, along with the others, launched Op-2. However, Giani Zail Singh, who was rewarded by Indira Gandhi in July 1982 with the country's highest post, that of president, was gradually sidelined by her, despite his continued interest in Punjab politics.

In March-April 1982, a trusted family friend (name withheld on request) from Patiala came to meet me in New Delhi and shared with me some interesting information he had gathered from Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) members in Patiala. The information went that sometime after the return of the Congress party to power in January 1980, the prime minister had taken a decision, as advised by Sanjay Gandhi, to win the next general elections by using the services of Bhindranwale to create a serious Hindu-Sikh divide and plant the fear of Khalistan in the minds of the majority community. With a majority baying for strongest possible action against Bhindranwale and his men, Indira Gandhi would in the end emerge as a 'strong leader' who saved the country from a 'monster' (which she herself had created). That would in turn help her party garner votes from grateful members of the majority community. When my friend asked the RSS members whether they had received the information from their headquarters or from Pawan Kumar Sharma, the Patiala based head of the Hindu Surakhsha Samiti, who had been rather active lately in creating a Hindu–Sikh divide, they parried his query.